

The Agartala Conspiracy Case

Having failed to stop the Six-Point Movement through repressive measures, the government adopted different tactics. In January 1968 a false case of treason was started by the government implicating Sheikh Mujibur Rahman as the main accused along with 35 other civil and military officials. They were accused of conspiring at Agartala in India to separate East Pakistan from Pakistan through an armed revolution with the help of India. A special tribunal was constituted to try this case. The accused persons pleaded not guilty. But they were tortured in an inhuman manner in order to extract confessions from them.

The people of East Pakistan rose in mass uprising against Ayub Khan in reaction to the Agartala Conspiracy Case. The Movement became more intense when Sergeant Zahurul Huq, one of the accused in this case, was martyred while in custody in the Dhaka Cantonment by police firing. The Movement was being led by the All-Party Students' Action Committee formed on the basis of the 11-Points. Finally, the government was compelled to withdraw the case in the face of a joint Movement by the public and the students.

The 11-Points of the Students

In December 1968, when the mass Movement was going on, the students of East Pakistan formed the All Party Students' Action Committee under the leadership of the then Vice-President of the Dhaka University Central Students Union (DUCSU) Tofael Ahmed. In January 1969 this Committee adopted the 11 Point Programme. The 6 Point Programme was included in these 11 Points.

The 11 Point Programme included such demands as the repeal of the University Ordinance, increasing educational facilities, regional autonomy, adult franchise, freedom of speech, nationalisation of big industries, increasing facilities for the peasants and the labourers, neutral foreign policy, withdrawal of Emergency and Public Safety Act, and the release of the political prisoners, etc.

The Mass Uprising of 1969

On 27 October 1968 President Ayub celebrated "The Decade of Development" pomp and grandeur. In reality, during this decade of military rule in Pakistan,

there were exploitation, deprivation and conspiracy instead of Development. Not only economy and politics, but also language and culture came under attack by the Pakistani rulers. These events made the common people of East Pakistan agitated and rebellious. Under such circumstances, the celebration of the so-called "Decade of Development" by President Ayub created a deep sense of agitation among the people. The political leaders formed the Democratic Action Committee (DAC) to oust the autocratic government of Ayub Khan and to establish the fundamental rights. The 11-Point Programme of the students added a new dimension to this agitated situation. *details*

On account of Ayub Khan's autocratic activities, mass discontent grew up not only in East Pakistan but also in West Pakistan. In November 1968 the students of West Pakistan protested violently when the public and the students were subjected to repression. Anti-Ayub discontent and agitation reached the climax during the period of December 1968 to February 1969 in East Pakistan and also in West Pakistan. An important event of this period was that on 6 December 1968 Maulana Bhasani led a huge crowd after a public meeting at the Palatan to gherao the Governor House. On 7 December, an unprecedented 'hartal' was observed in Dhaka and the bullets of the police and the EPR could not stop the people.

On 18 January 1969, while students were observing strike in support of the 11-Points, a group of students of Dhaka University violated section 144 and were arrested in wounded condition. On 20 January thousands of students and people clashed with the police and the EPR in an unequal fight. At one stage, the police retreated and a huge procession proceeded towards the Shaheed Minar. At this time Asaduzzaman, a student of the Law Department of the University of Dhaka was killed in police firing. On 21 January, a big procession paraded the streets of Dhaka with the blood stained shirt of Asad. This incident created an awareness among the people of this region, which subsequently led to the growth of the liberation struggle and nationalism.

After this, continuous 'hartal' over a few days culminated in the mass uprising on 24 January. On that day, firing of police killed Matiur Rahman, a student of Nabakumar school along with six others. The violent mob brought out the

biggest procession in Dhaka with the dead body of Shaheed Matiur and attacked the offices of "The Dainik Pakistan" and "The Daily Morning News". This public agitation gradually spread across the country. The wave of this Movement reached West Pakistan also. The Pakistani ruling clique, revengefully killed Sergeant Zahurul Huq, an accused in the Agartala Conspiracy Case on 15 February. Dr. Shamsuzzoha, ^(17 February) Professor, was killed in the Rajshahi University campus. When the news of his death reached Dhaka, thousands of students and people exploded in agitation. The situation became so acute and dangerous that curfew had to be imposed in the city of Dhaka at night. Alongside the 11-Point Movement of the students, this mass-discontent created such a mass-upsurge that it was not possible to suppress it even by deploying the army. Moreover, faced with such agitation, the Government of Pakistan was compelled to withdraw the Agartala Conspiracy Case on 22 February 1969. As a result, the fall of President Ayub also became inevitable. Under the pressure of the people, the Pakistani ruling clique was compelled to release Sheikh Mujib on 22 February.

On 10 March 1969 Ayub Khan invited all the political leaders to a Round Table Conference at Rawalpindi to make a solution of the constitutional problem of Pakistan. Sheikh Mujibur Rahman again placed the demands for autonomy on the basis of 6 Points and 11 Points at this Conference. When this demand was rejected Sheikh Mujib left the Conference. Thus with the failure of the talks the last attempt of Ayub Khan to stay in power became unsuccessful. On 21 March 1969 he removed his obedient Governor Monem Khan and appointed Dr. M. N. Huda the new Governor. At last, finding no other alternative, Ayub Khan handed over power to the Army Chief Agha Muhammad Yahya Khan. Thus, in the face of the mass-Movement, the military rule of Field Marshal Muhammad Ayub Khan came to an end.

The Rule of Yahya Khan